



CITY OF ST. JOSEPH, BARTLETT CENTER BOARD
RELEASE JOINT STATEMENT ON CHANGES

FOR MORE INFORMATION, CONTACT:
MIKE SCHUMACHER, CITY MANAGER
816.271.4680 or mschumacher@stjosephmo.gov

(September 21, 2026)
FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

The City of St. Joseph and the Bartlett Center board are issuing this statement to clarify the circumstances surrounding recent changes at the Bartlett Center and the City's involvement in discussions with the organization's board.

The priority of the City and the Bartlett Center board is to provide clarity about what has happened while working to minimize any disruption in services for the families who rely on the childcare services the organization provides. The City of St. Joseph owns the Horace Mann Community Center at 409 S. 18th Street, where the Bartlett Center operates its childcare center.

The City of St. Joseph did not participate in the Bartlett Center board's decision regarding its director or in the board's subsequent actions to dissolve the organization, and had no prior knowledge of the meeting or issues to be discussed.

As the City later learned, at a September 17 meeting with Bartlett Center board members, the organization's director offered her resignation. The board also voted to request a meeting with the City Manager to discuss the possibility of securing a new provider to take over services at the Bartlett Center.

City leadership was not aware of that board meeting or the topics discussed before it occurred, and no City representatives were present.

Members of the Bartlett Center board then requested a meeting with the City on September 18 to discuss ways to avoid an interruption in services and the potential transition of the program. During that discussion, City leadership was asked whether the City wanted the director to assist with the transition. That offer was declined. The director's employment status was not discussed by City officials with Bartlett Center board members.

“I can speak to what was discussed when we met, and the resignation of the Bartlett Center’s executive director was not requested,” City Manager Mike Schumacher said. “The City has no role in employment decisions between an employer and its employees. No City staff or leaders were present for conversations between the director and the Bartlett Center board, so we cannot speak to what the director was told during those conversations.”

The City of St. Joseph currently leases the Horace Mann Community Center to the Bartlett Center for \$2,905.12 per month, effective July 1, 2026. Previously, the rate was \$2,806.28. In addition to owning the facility, the City carries insurance on the building, pays its utilities and performs significant maintenance.

The City has been aware of financial challenges facing the Bartlett Center for more than a year. City leaders met with the organization’s director on December 22, 2025, after consecutive missed lease payments dating to August 2025 in a good-faith effort to discuss those issues and reach a payment agreement.

After hearing nothing more from the Bartlett Center following that meeting, the City issued a formal legal notice of default on January 12 regarding \$14,034.40 in missed payments, which at that point included January 2026. At the request of the Bartlett Center, City officials met with its director and board members on January 20 to again address the outstanding balance and establish a payment plan. At that meeting, the Bartlett Center provided the City with a check for \$8,420.64 to cover monthly lease payments for December 2025 and January and February 2026.

The Bartlett Center presented a plan at that meeting to then pay \$4,912.03 monthly from March through June to cover its ongoing regular lease costs as well as the remaining delinquent payments from September, October and November 2025. Those four payments were made.

However, the Bartlett Center failed to make lease payments for July, August and September 2026, and legal notice of the default in payment was once again issued. As of today, the Bartlett Center owes the City \$8,715.40 in lease fees. The City did indicate in the September 18 meeting that collecting that balance likely would be difficult in light of the Bartlett Center board’s stated plan to dissolve, but did not offer to waive collection of the amount owed in exchange for the removal of any Bartlett Center employee.

Issues have also been raised regarding Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) payments to the Bartlett Center. The CDBG program provides federal funding through the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD) to the City to support infrastructure, public facilities and service organizations, including organizations that provide childcare. CDBG funds are intended to support eligible expenses, including salaries and certain services, and cannot be used to pay rent.

The Bartlett Center receives CDBG funding through the City of St. Joseph. To receive these funds, agencies are required to submit reimbursement requests with supporting documentation to the City. The City has requested that the Bartlett Center’s director submit these requests monthly to allow the City to make timely disbursements of allocated funds. In several cases,

reimbursement requests were submitted incorrectly or late, leading to delays in releasing CDBG funds from the City to the Bartlett Center.

Against this backdrop, the City and the Bartlett Center board are now focused on maintaining continuity of childcare services and supporting the families who rely on the program.

“It’s no secret to anyone the Bartlett Center has faced financial difficulty for months, even years,” Jayne Roberts, Bartlett Center president, said. “While it is a heartbreaking decision to dissolve the Bartlett Center’s nonprofit status, it is our primary responsibility to ensure care is continued for our children, their parents, the staff and the community.”

At this time, the City and the Bartlett Center board are working with other community partners on a plan to provide continuity of childcare services for families served by the Bartlett Center. The hope is to have a temporary provider step in until the City can move to a full request-for-proposal process to identify a permanent childcare provider to operate at the Horace Mann building.

The City and the Bartlett Center board remain focused on supporting a smooth transition and minimizing disruption to the families who depend on these services.